THE NLH PLAYER'S PLO SURVIVAL CARD

8 EXPENSIVE HOLD'EM HABITS TO DROP BEFORE YOU SIT IN A PLO GAME

By River Potter · PLO Specialist, War of Poker

You already know how to play poker. The errors below come from applying accurate Hold'em instincts to a game that changed the inputs. Four hole cards mean players make stronger hands, pick up bigger draws, and hold far more equity against one another — so the instinct that was right in Hold'em becomes the expensive one.

HOLD'EM INSTINCT	→ PLO DANGER	→ RIVER POTTER FIX
An overpair is a strong made hand	Bare AA on JT9 has to fold to real action. Four-card hands make straights and sets constantly.	Aces gain from suits, connectivity and low SPR — not from being aces. A correct preflop raise with aces is regularly followed by a correct flop fold.
Top two pair is close to the nuts	Opponents hold four cards, so sets and straights arrive far more often.	Treat bare two pair as a **medium** hand. Ask what beats it now and what it improves to.
A set is a stack-off hand	Top set usually is at low SPR. Bottom set multiway is often drawing to one improvement.	Flopping a set and holding a stack-off hand are different claims. Check: is a straight already possible? Is there a flush draw? What do I redraw to?
Count your outs	A card that makes your straight and someone else's better straight is not an out.	Count **clean** outs. Point to the two hole cards and three board cards that make each hand, then grade every out: nut · clean · vulnerable · dirty.
The made hand is the goal	A strong made hand routinely faces a draw with plenty of equity against it.	The made hand **plus its redraw** is the goal. Ask what you improve to after you are already ahead.
Equities run close, so I can call	Close equity does not pay for a bad price, poor position, or a dominated draw.	Price the call: **amount you still owe ÷ the final pot after your call.** Count only the pot you are eligible to win.
The rule of four estimates my equity	It overstates large PLO draws, double-counts overlapping cards, and prices two cards when you are buying one.	A non-all-in call usually buys **one** more card, not two. Count the cards that actually win against the range that is betting.
A blocker means I have the hand	A blocker removes combinations from the opponent. It is not showdown value.	Use blockers as **information, not permission**, and to settle close decisions — never to override what the player has already shown you.

TWO MORE, AND THEY'RE MECHANICAL. Exactly **two** hole cards and exactly **three** board cards play — always, no exceptions. And a low SPR describes the size of the remaining bet. It does not describe your cards.

FOUR QUESTIONS, EVERY STREET

HAND · SPR · PLAYER · EQUITY

One lens, used the same way on every street. Update it whenever a new card or a new action changes the situation.

HAND	SPR	PLAYER	EQUITY
What do all four cards contribute? Name the current nuts, your made hand, draws, redraws and blockers.	How much remains against this opponent compared with the pot? What size and later decisions does this action create?	What does this action mean from this opponent? How confident is the read, and who is left to act?	What share does the hand expect against the relevant range at this price? Which outs win, chop or stay vulnerable?

STREET	ASK
Preflop	Does the structure fit this position and action? · What happens if somebody raises again?
Flop	What is the current nuts? · Which components give me equity against the range that continues?
Turn	What changed? · Which river cards win or tie? · Does the present price justify the next investment?
River	What worse hands call? · What better hands fold? · What bluffs justify my call?
Between hands	Has the effective depth, straddle, lineup, or my decision quality changed?

$2/$5, 60 BB — NUMBERS WORTH REMEMBERING	AMOUNT
Starting stack	**$300**
Unopened pot raise	**$17**
Common nonblind pot 3-bet over a lone $17 open	**$58**
Heads-up pot 4-bet after $17 → $58	**$181**

READ THIS BEFORE YOU USE THEM. These assume an eight-handed, unstraddled $2/$5 game with exact-chip pot-limit counting and no extra callers. **Room rules and callers change the exact totals** — a player who already has a blind in owes a different amount, a straddle changes every number, and some rooms count or round differently. Confirm the room's convention, and ask the dealer for the pot when you are unsure.

Want the complete shallow-stack system?

SHORT STACK PLO

A Practical Strategy for Shallow-Stack Live Pot-Limit Omaha

warofpoker.com/short-stack-plo

SCAN TO OPEN

THE BOOK	THE FIELD KIT
Complete strategy — hand construction, preflop, SPR and commitment, flop, draws and redraws, turn, river, live exploits, session and stack management, and ten fully worked hands.	Seven printable tools: decision maps · pot geometry · draw quality · river card · player reads · session and hand review workbook · 20-hand capstone quiz.

WAR OF POKER